

Q.7a (20 marks): Summarize Margaret Mead's contributions to the study of gender and adolescence in Samoa. Analyse...

Q.7) (a) Summarize Margaret Mead's contributions to the study of gender and adolescence in Samoa. Also analyse the controversy sparked by Derek Freeman's critique of Mead's findings. (20 marks)

Margaret Mead belonged to the culture & personality school with her idea being based upon Cultural determinism.

Contribution to study of gender & adolescence in Samoa

① In her work, "Coming of age in Samoa", Mead studied 68 girls from pre, post, and during puberty stage

② As her result of study, Mead showed that Samoan girls when compared to their American counterparts did not experience behavioral or attitudinal issues.

③ Reasoning for this was given as

(a) It is due to the Culture that did not experience anxiety.

- ⑤ Samoan girls are aware of sex, reproduction, menstruation etc and can freely converse with their parents on it, even pre-puberty.
- ⑥ This is unlike American teenagers for whom puberty is a sudden stage without any prior knowledge.
- ⑦ Due to this, Samoan girls are able to take [puberty] just as an event unlike Americans for whom it is difficult.
- ⑧ she also said how Samoan are less [emotional] and hence pre-marital sex is accepted.
- For Americans, pre-marital sex is rebellious and hence teenage teenagers act in rebellion.

Criticism by Derek Freeman

- ① He said that Mead's study was flawed.
- ② Samoan girls also experienced as much if not more anxiety than American girls.
- ③ Pre-marital sex was not allowed.
- ④ strict virginity complex existed.
- ⑤ Issues like rape, forced sex in Samoa.
- ⑥ Results fabricated to counter G. Stanley Hall's theory that adolescence change are universally driven by hormonal.

Freeman justified his criticism as follows

- ① He did his fieldwork in Samoa.
- ② Lack of command on language for Mead meant dependence on informants.

③ Informants hoaxed her into and gave her translations as per her own choice.

However, Freeman's views are not justified

① He did his study 30 years after Mead.

② He did not study the same village as Mead $\Rightarrow$ his justification was that culture won't be polar opposite

③ Lack of any other significant anthropological contribution.

Freeman presented an alternative to Mead's views, however Mead's contribution to field has been immense bringing new understandings to study.